

EASTERN EUPHORIA

Upbeat about the rise of Asia, Mahbubani rues that the West is still imprisoned in hegemonic interpretations



**THE NEW ASIAN HEMISPHERE:
THE IRRESISTIBLE SHIFT OF
GLOBAL POWER TO THE EAST**
by KISHORE MAHBUBANI
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■ By Pratap Bhanu Mehta

Amidst the din of daily struggles, inept politics and immediate worries, it is very easy to lose sight of the profound changes and shifts of power taking place in the world. Kishore Mahbubani's book has two inter-related aims. The first is to demonstrate that Asia is undergoing an unprecedented economic, cultural and social change, lifting millions out of poverty, expanding aspirations, fostering innovation and giving birth to possibilities of a new kind of geo-politics. For the first time, the citizens of most Asian countries feel that they can actually make their own destiny. The second aim is to argue that the West is still, in many ways, slow to understand the character of these changes. It is imprisoned in ideas about Asia borrowed from the past, or worse, in its own hegemonic interpretations.

Although the author says he is an optimist, and the euphoria about Asia that emerges from these pages sounds almost too good to be true, the book is in many ways deeply pessimistic. It is pessimistic in its assessment of the West. While Mahbubani is too sophisticated a writer to engage in simple Asia-versus-the-West polemics, there is an underlying sense that the West, particularly the US, will not give space for three propositions. First, that history and culture should matter in determining the kinds of political institutions a society should have; the project of creating a convergence around democracy is simply mistaken. The second point is that the West will continue to overestimate its power. At one level, *The New Asian Hemisphere* is an exemplification of the confidence it describes. The author characterises the US's position on a range of issues, from global warming to nuclear

proliferation, from dealing with Islam to understanding China, as simply incompetent. And third, the hegemony of western ideas will refuse to acknowledge the novelty of new Asian approaches.

While Mahbubani describes the Asian orientation towards the world as broadly pragmatic, he is also keen to refute the charge that there is no serious thinking going on in Asia. The standard criticism of Asia's rise is that it is often a strange combination of mimicry and outright instrumentalism; all that is good in it is borrowed from the West, or it is simply too caught up in making money to bother about ideas. Mahbubani believes the Asian story is, above all, a story of immense

contribution to international relations may be just that: it is premised on a deeper appreciation of global diversity and live-and-let-live. Mahbubani's account plays down the role of nationalism in Asia. With the exception of Japan for a brief period, Asian nationalism has not been allied to an imperial project. But this also explains why the rise of Asia will not, in the short run, change the rules of the world order. Most Asian powers are quite content building their own strength, rather than worrying about making or remaking the world in their own image.

The argument of this book might be misunderstood by nationalists who harbour a certain resentment against the West. But Mahbubani's



BRAND ASIA: The Asian story is that of immense improvisation

improvisation rather than mimicry. It borrows many elements from the West, but transforms them or adds new ones as required by circumstances. Secondly and more subtly, he seems to suggest that there is one underlying difference between the West and Asia. While countries in Asia strongly believe in strengthening their societies and states, they do not harbour the imperialistic ambitions of the West. Indeed the great Asian contri-

concerns are more about alerting the West to the dangers of its ossified thinking on a range of issues; its objective is to make the world a better place, not retreat into nativism of assorted kinds. In the process, Mahbubani sometimes overstates his case and minimises the strains within Asian societies. However, he has given a wonderfully provocative, clear, breezy and accessible forewarning about the profound changes that will shape the world in the coming decades. And history seems to be on his side. ■